

18 Speaking approximately

English has a number of useful phrases to describe approximate quantities and amounts. You can use them when a number is unknown or roughly accurate.

⚙️ **New language** Generalization

Aa **Vocabulary** Approximate quantity phrases

🧩 **New skill** Talking about numbers

18.1 KEY LANGUAGE APPROXIMATE QUANTITIES

If you have specific figures, it may be useful to give them. However, you may need to use more general terms if you do not have the figures or you want to avoid repetition.



3 out of 15 students live off campus.



In some cases, students live off campus.

"Some" is a very unspecific word. The only numbers it could not mean in this example are none, one, or 15.



18.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES APPROXIMATE QUANTITIES

A minority is less than half, but often refers to much less than half.

In a minority of cases,
In a few cases, } employers provide funding for education.



TIP
"Minority" and "majority" are often qualified, for example "small minority" or "vast majority."

"Most" and "majority" refer to more than half.

In most cases,
In the majority of cases, } students can contact their professors online.



These unspecific references could mean a majority or minority of cases.

In some cases,
In a number of cases, } students can live in dorms on campus.

